

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 15

ILLINOIS
WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Illinois's family courts and child-welfare system.

180

ILLINOIS FAMILIES ON RECORD · 299
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 14 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
OCTOBER 14, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
46 OF 102

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · ILLINOIS

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in Illinois. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Neal Cerne

JUDGE · DUPAGE COUNTY 18TH JUDICIAL CIRCUIT · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Violated my ADA Rights under Title II. Knowingly accepted my spouse's fraudulent financial affidavits, Ex-parte collusion to refuse to reinstate the financial status quo after Madison unlawfully took sole control over millions of dollars of my assets, leaving me penniless. Collusion refusal to enforce all financial protective orders on dissipation of over $700,000 within months by Madison while the court facilitated domestic violence against me, and more. Colluded in a scheme to divert the possession of my home and it equity to a third party. Facilitated my spouse in stealing $5,000,000 in crypto currency and other assets, forcing me to rely on welfare. Facilitated my spouse in depriving me of health care and medical treatment."*

> *"Suspended all Father's parenting time sua sponte, relief no party requested, despite every evaluator opposing restriction, no endangerment finding, no DCFS or police finding, and the court's own written order acknowledging the conduct did not warrant professional intervention; simultaneously stated from the bench he was "ready to terminate on the spot." And the "quite frankly I saved your son""*

> *"Refused hearings, refused to admit evidence refused to consider evidence refuse to consider filings by the other side basically refused anything that would prove my case"*

> *"Denied an order of protection my teenage daughter filed against her father after there was substantial evidence showing a history of violence by him"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/il-neal-cerne/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Antoinette L. Granholm

JUDGE · WILL · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"No, due process, ignored evidence, unethical, harassment, denied motions, defamation of professionals publicly. Denied hearings, denied my emotions, defamation of medical professionals Denied hearing, and ignored evidence, delayed notification, not the call, bias, edited documents, dismiss motions, unprofessional, no due process Denied motion without hearing without due process"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/il-antoinette-l-granholm/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Carlo Colosimo

JUDGE · KENDALL COUNTY · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Denied many motions eithout reviewing my facts. Total bias!"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/il-carlo-colosimo/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Kelly Stephen

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · MADISON · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Refused to investigate children to include their home(s), friends, people at their school. Ignored vital information submitted. Did not investigate children, not any calls to me, no home visits, didn't talk to teachers. She told my attorney that me not agreeing to 50/50 custody on a Friday forced an interruption on his Disney trip and I was told v cause of that my children would be moved to their fathers. They were moved the next court date"*

> *"Denied my due process for her personal vacation. Running court continuance to keep the case open to take money from hurting parents. She charges $8500 to hire for family court because she controls family court without her position."*

> *"Support abuser to have custody"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/il-kelly-stephen/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

ILLINOIS AT A GLANCE.

Across 180 Illinois families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED
299
179 of 180 families reported child counts

MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN
$123,075
median across 112 families reporting 3+ categories

MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
14
of parenting time

WENT PRO SE
48.9%
88 of 180 who answered; 74 of 180 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTIES REPRESENTED
180	1.7	179 of 180	46

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Illinois families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

03 THE COST OF ILLINOIS FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	133	$22,700	$93,925	$12,492,020
Lost Wages	96	$20,000	$95,162	$9,135,540
Other Court Fees	74	$635	$11,961	$885,139
Therapy / Evaluations	84	$2,000	$7,983	$670,550
Reunification Services	57	$500	$2,300	$131,125
GAL Fees	112	$7,000	$24,158	$2,705,650
Asset Loss [1]	82	$47,500	—	—
Median Family Burden (112 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$123,075	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($47,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost	14	1.2 yrs
Mean months lost	26	2.2 yrs
Total across all families	3,136	261.3 yrs

04 WHO IS REPORTING · ILLINOIS

Most families documenting in Illinois are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	104	58%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	22	12%
Not provided	18	10%
Case closed: within last 2 years	17	9%
Not in court but still affected	8	4%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only	94	52%
Both Family Court and CPS	63	35%
CPS Only	13	7%
Unknown	9	5%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)	1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

3 – 5 years	47	26%
1 – 3 years	47	26%
5 – 10 years	37	21%
Over 10 years	21	12%
6 months – 1 year	16	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access	45	25%
50/50 Joint	41	23%
Visitation Only	40	22%
Full Custody	25	14%
Children in Foster Care	16	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Cook	37	23%
Kane	11	7%
Madison	10	6%
Lake	8	5%
Kendall	7	4%
Will	7	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	60	33%
High Conflict Divorce	40	22%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	23	13%
Other	21	12%
Other: (Short answer)	9	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — ILLINOIS

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Illinois comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *Destroyed every chance of me having a normal life and family. Cause my kids trauma and heartbreak they should have never been through*
>
> — HOLLY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

I have provided sufficient evidence from how my children were not wanting to see their father due to emotional neglect, verbal abuse, blamed children for the conflict between him and his girlfriend. Children left stranded by the girlfriend when my ex husband and girlfriend got [...]

— ILLINOIS PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM ILLINOIS

The judge and opposing attorney covered up sexual abuse that my ex-boyfriend did my two children. The court, and the opposing attorney and the prosecutor contrived child abduction against me, made it appear as if I was not even the mother or sole custodial parent of my children. [...]

— MISTY

They haveterminated my rights cps in illinois is major corrupted even when all services were completed they still Adopted my children out to a women who could have children and was close to a caseworker

— ELIZABETH

Family court has destroyed the innocence and robbed the dreams of my children and my motherhood. Family court has become the abuser and the weapon of my abuser. Family court is responsible for creating poverty homelessness and generational trauma.

— STEPHANIE

Completely ripped my family apart. My children are traumatized. We will never be the same again.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *The court has destroyed my children's lives and repeatedly facilitated the abuse of my children.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

This traumatized my family because my daughter was punished for speaking up about abuse and I was punished for protecting her.

— BRIDGET

Dcfs the Chicago police the cook county public Guardians office and the cook county states Attorneys office along with the Attorney General's office violated all of my family's civil rights and my children suffered horrible irreparable physical damage for 16 years without a [...]

— JERRY

The system has terrorized and tortured me. They have stolen my son, my kids brother. And they have created lifelong scars that will never heal.

— LAUREN

Dcfs took my children during covid. I've missed out on so much, they ruined our lives.

— JENNA

Removing kids from mom after 6/8 years of primary caregiver status for 60 days no contact and now 4 hours a week supervised has been massively traumatic, and shocking. They have not been to their home in 4 months. My C-PTSD is so extreme I'm unable to work at the moment.

— JILLIAN

The courts and GAL have allowed my ex to use the children to try to hurt me and have destroyed a happy healthy relationship I had with my boys. The court has and still is illegally taking disability income for things other than child support under threat of jail.

— DEREK

It has destroyed my life and my child is suffering in the hands of our abuser.

— LINSI

This system has deprived me and my children's rights and destroyed my family. There is nothing that can bring back the time they stole with my children.

— JENNY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *It's cost me thousands of dollars just to have a private attorney I want people to know I will never give up*
>
> — ALYSSA

Over $2 million has been spent on my daughter's head for over a decade of attempting to escape abuse. Society does not believe children who have been sexually abused. My case is a prime example of cover-up, fraud and human trafficking.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have been a victim of ongoing domestic violence and financial abuse since 2023, which was facilitated by four DuPage County family court judges. Today this is happening to me. Tomorrow, it could happen to you or someone you love seeking protection under the law.

— JACKIE

This system has consistently abused me, gaslighted me, slandered me, assassinated my character. All while the judge looked me right in the eyes and said you're not a victim here. My children and I will never recover from the damage done. We can only hope to pick up the pieces [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Do not file anything in regard to abuse of a mother or child in Mchenry county especially if the father has stalked you. The judges gals and attorneys all align together against you. They talk openly about each case with each other between recesses in front of me! The system is [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has destroyed two children and maybe more as a sexual predator has access to the children's friends who he has started giving gifts to which he hides in his room. The GAL threaten my withness with fostercare if she didnt go back to her abuser now my child talks [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my hopes & my dreams. Took away the only thing I ever wanted to be the most of and that was being the best mother I could be to my girls. My life was flipped upside down over night. I had idea my baby daddy was working with CPS behind my back.

— JENNIFER

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *It's completely destroyed us both emotionally and physically.*
>
> — AMANDA

It has failed me from being a parent to my kids when I had done nothing wrong. My mother has paid off judges and lawyers to help take my children from me. She made friends with the mayor of the town and his wife going and having dinners with them, she made friends with the [...]

— KAYLA

Enable the abuser to continue using our child as a pawn

— MELISSA

This corrupt system has broken, stole, lied, and humiliated my family.

— AMANDA

Destroyed everything. Scarred my child.

— CAITLYN

Severe PTSD for me and trauma for my children. Tragically limited the potential of my children's future from what it could have been.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Kidnapped our 3 children and drove my wife 2 hours away for a psych evaluation while I was out of town for business

— BRANDON

Losing my 2 oldest was the hardest not being hear in my youngest case is even worse I currently have only one case going in family court and my mental health is still used against me. If there was a way to get all my kids back I would but IL is so corrupt and I get turned down [...]

— HANNAH

False allegations, false orders of protection.

— KRISTINA JO

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *My little family was destroyed. Instead of stepping up and taking some of the burden off my raising my kids 99% alone, dad came after me when I was in a vulnerable spot and essentially scammed the system to steal my kids from me.*
>
> — NINA

Let's just that there are no words to describe what the system has done to my kids and I. Just no words at all.

— HOLLY

The system has fabricated false allegations, violated my constitutional rights, and blackmailed me or blackballed me into taking a Alfred please or no contest that I never wanted to accept and even made it known on the record.

— DAN

I am absolutely destroyed. All I do is cry for my child. I can't eat or sleep. The system has ruined my life. I am in law enforcement and question our legal system to the point where I no longer believe in the child civil side of it and Divorce side

— JASON

Caused us separation anxiety due to family disruption.. trauma pain.. health problems

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Destroyed time cannot ge5 nack.

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This system has torn my whole life apart and put someone in charge of my sons life that shouldn't be

— MICHELLE

The GAL in our case "felt sorry" for mom and ignored the blatant lies, physical abuse and other psychological factors in our case even when documented by us and licensed health care workers.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

+drug tested father - court continues to attempt reunification counseling despite this and despite the fact that children, ages 12 and 15, continue to express the desire for no contact. Mother has a plenary OP for 2 years granted by the court against father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

101 Illinois parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 40 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — ILLINOIS

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Illinois families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> Destroyed every chance of me having a normal life and family. Cause my kids trauma and heartbreak they should have never been through
>
> — HOLLY

> The judge and opposing attorney covered up sexual abuse that my ex-boyfriend did my two children. The court, and the opposing attorney and the prosecutor contrived child abduction against me, made it appear as if I was not even the mother or sole custodial parent of my children. They used that crime that they falsified to steal my children from me and keep them from me. There was never a custody hearing. there was no custody switch. It was just their contrived crime. There was no GAL. The judge would not allow a GAL.
>
> — MISTY

> They haveterminated my rights cps in illinois is major corrupted even when all services were completed they still Adopted my children out to a women who could have children and was close to a caseworker
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— LINSI

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Do not file anything in regard to abuse of a mother or child in Mchenry county especially if the father has stalked you. The judges gals and attorneys all align together against you. They talk openly about each case with each other between recesses in front of me! The system is rigged in favor of the criminals. Do not file anything abuse related in Mchenry County or risk losing your child. The only reason I didn't lose my child completely is bc I learned to play the game protect my case with a crazy amount of intuition determination and grit.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I have provided sufficient evidence from how my children were not wanting to see their father due to emotional neglect, verbal abuse, blamed children for the conflict between him and his girlfriend. Children left stranded by the girlfriend when my ex husband and girlfriend got into an argument and ex husband proceeded to yell at the children that it is the kids fault kept the children in the cold yelling outside. Children called the police and there is a police report that the kids stated that they were afraid. and threatened. statement from my son stating that father was doing drugs such as shrooms GAL was notified and ignored. Son was administrated marijuana and statement was given by my son to the principal that his father gave him weed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has destroyed two children and maybe more as a sexual predator has access to the children's friends who he has started giving gifts to which he hides in his room. The GAL threaten my withness with fostercare if she didnt go back to her abuser now my child talks sexually with adult men online and I was told that I monitor her to closely and was told I could not monitor them. I am a cyber security engineer who has worked on child monitoring apps for fortune 10 companies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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It has failed me from being a parent to my kids when I had done nothing wrong. My mother has paid off judges and lawyers to help take my children from me. She made friends with the mayor of the town and his wife going and having dinners with them, she made friends with the sheriff and cops and any one who was elite and of importance. She talked bad about me to my community and I couldn't even go into a grocery store and hold my head up high because everyone was giving me looks. My kids love me and my mom is brain washing my kids into thinking I'm a bad mom and that she is their mom now. It has tore me and my kids life apart. I have two other daughters now and they don't get to see or be involved

— KAYLA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> This child trafficking court has made angry children, unable to function properly in society
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> The court system allowed years of costly, endless interventions and unchecked abuses of power that destroyed my relationship with my son and fractured my family beyond repair. I was forced to navigate an exhausting maze of custody evaluations, therapy, supervised visits, and ever-changing requirements that ultimately deprived me of my son and the irreplaceable milestones of his childhood. What was presented as a system designed to protect children instead became a system that isolated me from my son, exhausted my resources, and robbed our family of years we can never get back.” The abuse of power I experienced through the family court system left me emotionally devastated, financially drained, and permanently separated from the everyday joys and milestones of my son’s life
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> The corrupt family court system ignored documented evidence of abuse, annihilated my life’s savings, robbing my child of her future, and forced my child into the arms of her abuser.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> It has destoryed me. I can’t sleep, my kids get a shell of a father because I am constantly worried about the next false allegation, delay, gatekeeping.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system has destroyed my life and everything I have, causing me sever pain and crippling sadness

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

What happened cost me depression, thousands of dollars and above all time with my children I will NEVER get back. Nothing is the same anymore. NOTHING

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex-wife made false accusations to hurt me financially and and hurt me me and my family emotionally. The one hurt the most was my son, not being able to see his other side of his family and friends. My ex-wife used the courts to do so. They removed my son with 0 evidence.

— VICTOR

I have no family , I'm completely broken

— SAMANTHA

The family court ecosystem specifically provided over by the second judge in my dissolution, deprive me of my peace, my joy, my health, my reputation, my assets, my stability, my future. I got my kids back on my own.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I don’t know where to begin, the system has failed my children and me to our rights. Has put me in a depression state has stolen time and money from our family. It has broken my trust in all this I will never come to the court for help because of the unfairness they cause in order to gain money. Broken my soul.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost the daily relationship eith my only child. She is 4 and they forced her to stay with her abuser.I am only allowed to have 1 supervised visit for 1 hour a week only. I lost my job,car apartment and had to file bankruptcy.

— GINA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

They didn't just take my children from me, they took my stability, my time, my peace, my reputation, my ability to work, my trust in people, and two years of my life I can never get back."

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My caseworker has not only erased me, she nearly has buried me.

— MISTY

It's made my faith in Christ impenetrable. I believe in his promise—all things work together for the good of those who love the Lord.

— KATIE

Mentally kidnapped my kids

— RYAN

Broken me, making my daughter hate me, putting alot of stress on my current family

— JOSE

It has taken way my son who does child from our family and her sisters

— ST

DEVISTATED the family , ruined our lives

— ANDREA

Split family, kept father from child for 1 year Child trauma

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Post separation abuse from my ex, refusal to hold him accountable for violating court orders

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The level of stress and anxiety caused by this case has led to extreme uncertainty and has taken a lot of time away from my work and family. I have lost so much trust in attorney's and the system.

— TRAVIS

It impacted me by causing me to suffer severe distress emotionally, i no longer get to see my three children and I live in constant fear of my ex doing more to be since he still stalks me. This has made living a normal life impossible for me and it has left my children with abusive men.

— AMBER

Destroyed our lives, financial wellbeing, trust, future, security, mental health, and ability to live a “regular”, safe, healthy life for both child and mother. It’s created a life of walking on egg shells for almost 10 years, and no end in sight.

— CHRIS

Ruined my life &taken time away me nor my family will never get back. TRAMATIZED US

— SAMANTHA

Alienation of my Children

— JUSTIN

Made us out to be the bad guy without looking into anything

— CHRISTY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Ripped my family apart. Caused conflict and abandonment with my family. Prolonged my ppd and made me go through pain from c-section due to not filling my prescription for pain medication in fear that a dirty test regardless of prescription would cause devastating damage.

— REBECKA

Caused stress in the household constantly watching who we talk to and what's said.

— CHRISTY

Judge listened to ex parte communication from stepmom which she filed a third party intervenor to my divorce case after my ex has died. Put a false Order of Protection against me with no hearing until it was dismissed a year later by my laywer. My ex husband worked with everyone in the same courthouse Im fighting for my daughter.

— KATHLEEN

This has significantly hurt my relationship with my daughter in more ways than I could have ever imagined. They have consistently taken more and more rights away as if I don't deserve to make any decisions in her life. My daughter used to scream bloody murder and cling onto me during exchanges and the courts deem that to be "what's best for the child", now she is much older and still begging to be with me and not understanding why my son always gets to be with me and she rarely gets to see us. This system is unbelievably cruel and unfair and has caused so much harm, pain, suffering, time, trauma, loss of funds, and time together that we will never get back. Before this happened I was a stay at home mom, with her all day every day to getting everything taken away with a snap of a finger. Let's just say in this case money has done the talking and I'm not the one with the money. I'm struggling so bad but I will never give up. Just seeing the courthouse puts me in a state of panic because all I know is what has been done to myself and my daughter inside of that place. Complete strangers that "know" what's best for my child is the most ridiculous thing ever. Records show that she has struggled significantly during these back and forth periods when they were deciding how often I could see her then tried to take the little time I do get, away. My all A's & B's student was failing all of her classes during the month she was not allowed to see or talk to me. But that's what's best, right??!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

GUARDIAN AD LITEM OVERREACH AND FAILURE TO ACT - GAL's conduct exceeds the scope of a neutral investigative role and is inconsistent with Illinois Supreme Court Rule 905.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Dekalb county Family court system has allowed the lies, abuse, control multnipulation and alienation from my boys to continue because they are about breaking laws and not following through with contempt charges holding the wrong parent accountable for their wrong doings.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system and child welfare system fails to respond adequately and promptly to valid safety concerns. The costs associated range from emotional to financial and perpetuates systemic financial abuse and gender inequality.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They system has constantly terminated my rights over and over even with completed assignments and ect they lie and drag on cases so they can keep the child then terminate ur rights bridge sabbia will agree to terminate your rights on her terms and how fast she wants it done . Juste kathry karayannis would agree and proceed judge kathryn karayannis isnt a stable judgeto be kn thebstand and need to be evaluated for her to be in thebstand to make reasonable decisions for family beside take power and control and due process and also violatioof constitutional rights that she tends to say and cant explan her under oath or speak on her oath . A judge should know her oath and also refuse to not give u her oath she does.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is only here to make money and sell your kids ! They don’t care about you . Then they play this game n literally make u think u have mental health problems!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

With getting out of the abuse I really feel like my voice was never heard and told that I have to still communicate and work with this person and forced to hand over my baby to this person weekly even if he takes him for weeks with out a known address

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I recently read the quote “blessed that I was chosen to raise these beautiful souls.” And I had to take a step back emotionally because no ounce of me feels chosen to be a mother by this court. Parents are recognizing that we have done all we can to escape the abuse and heal but now we are opening our eyes to a system built upon greed. We have faith that what is done in the dark will come to light.

— CRISTINA

The psychological and financial abuse should be considered family terrorism because thats EXACTLY what it is. They terrorize you mentally then extort your hard earned money and savings on the "best interest of the child." The years of therapy I have been through has only made it somewhat bearable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

A judge suspended all of my parenting time with my son, relief no one asked for, despite every single evaluator opposing restriction, no finding of endangerment, and a written order acknowledging my conduct didn’t warrant professional intervention; my child was taken not because I failed him, but because a system with no accountability decided it could.

— STAVROS

taken everthing away from me and my childs current and future

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has caused irreparable damage to my young children. We can never get their childhood back. They are continually punished for things over which they have no control. God will provide justice in the end.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I will never get my sons and daughters back in the same condition as when they were taken. Sadly, they too have lost the mother they were kidnapped from.

— MONIQUE

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Dehumanized and robbed us, then asked to pay for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Yeah, the system has refused to adjudicate one fact in every single case in every single file and every single quote while acting on allegations in here say without any factual evidence from the other side and I'm not exaggerating

— JEFFREY

Has ripped my teenage daughter away placed her in behavior hospital where she's mentally declined because no placement so she's enprisoned against will drugged daily and begs to come home the PTSD inflicted will cause her to never ask for help and our case warranted a intact get your crap together first but they chose removal

— BOBBIE

Having to grieve the loss of children that aren't dead is something that can't be put into words. The pain is unbearable but you have to survive in case they come back...it's a horrible way to live.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is taking my 5 year old daughter from her mother and siblings on fake alienation claims without viewing any of my children's sexual anuse evidence

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The damage to my family is catastrophic. Its been 9 years of torment. My youngest son was only 2 yrs old, and I've been told he doesn't remember me and thinks my exes current wife is his mom and they let him think so. Hes 11 years old now. Ive haven't seen my daughter either and I have no idea if she remembers me at all. My oldest is 22 now and we are just beginning to have a relationship. I am grateful for that but I mourn the relationship we used to have, the one we should have, the one we deserve to have. None of us are the people we would have been, we are all more broken, all more damaged, changed, robbed of our rightful place in each other's lives and not one person is better for it. A family destroyed for nothing.

— AMBER

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Put me to the brink of death or wanting to kill

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system failed me as a child in the welfare system, at 30 years old seeing no real change, accountability or resources while my children are now in DCFS custody is quite scary, they're understaffed and not held accountable. We now live in fear waiting for reunification, in which we have been targets of DCFS since 2019.

— STARKESHIA

For more than seven years, this system has replaced my children's childhood with litigation, supervision, and conflict, while stripping us of ordinary family experiences and irreplaceable milestones that can never be recovered. It has emotionally, financially, and psychologically devastated my family while prolonging separation without a meaningful path toward reunification.

— MEGHAN

I have made it to the other side, my fear is that it will take my son a long time to heal from the emotional damage. I have NEVER lost my faith in God and he has carried me through.

— TIFFANY

Watching the person I love the systematically dismantled by a court process that prioritizes spite over truth has been an agonizing exercise and helplessness we have endured the weight of these false accusations together standing firm as the system attempts to turn our reality into a weapon against our future.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

From the very beginning it was clearly gender bias and quickly taught me that the court will allow your ex to stalk you through 3rd parties and hold nobody accountable. No faith in the system. Lost some parenting time do it

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

My daughter and I have been torn apart our bond is being destroyed and I feel like I am losing everything I have ever worked so hard for and loved - my entire life has been taken from me and then I am being punished for it on top of everything. My baby girl needs to come home before things are made even harder or worse for us as time is allowed to go on like this. She has almost died now more than once while being forced out of my care and medical neglect has been allowed by dcfs and the court to occur with no acknowledgement accountability or repercussions for allowing child to fall four feet onto her head and not being seen by medical professionals for over 24 hours / she broke the baseline of her skull and fractured the cartilage in nose and various points in the surrounding areas - have documents photos and video of the fall and no one seems to care that she could have had a seizure- brain bleed - injury to the spine or connective points surrounding the skull and neck vertebrae- no checking for concussion or anything at all total medical neglect. When I called foster grandparents to understand what happened then all of my contact was diminished and taken from me as I was being punished for caring and being concerned about my child. I have every document and recording to support my statements and no one will listen or give me the time of day. I am scared for my child's life the longer she stays in their care

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I was never heard in court, when I asked to be heard I was denied to speak, and maintenance was awarded to her because she claimed she had been diagnosed with cancer halfway through the divorce, there was no proof of this just her saying it...

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Services with held not offered in a timely manner ended up losing parental Fitness and one trial have to pay child support on the other three don't even get a joint custody or visitation schedule for the other3

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It cost me my whole world. I made mistakes and I take full responsibility for them but people can change and learn from their mistakes and I've done that. They are using my past and my prior cases and court involvement as a reason for me to not be able to parent now and I truly believe they are in the wrong. I'm a great mother and I love my kids. What they are doing isn't right and they are causing more damage by putting such a young baby who only knows his mom and dad into a foster home with complete strangers.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

> Over years of litigation and ongoing conflict, the family court process and my ex's conduct have created instability, severe emotional strain, and division within our family, placing the children in the middle of adult issues instead of protecting their emotional, mental and physical wellbeing. The repeated litigation, financial instability, interference with parenting time, and ongoing conflict have significantly impacted both me and the children emotionally, mentally, physically, financially, and relationally, while undermining consistency and security for the children.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> My infant daughter has been thrown into the arms of strangers who do not have her best interest in mind. They're treating this like a game to be won, and as if she's a thing to play tug of war with. Her development is at stake right now. She's never been without me. It's not healthy to thrust a baby into 50/50 when she has a secure attachment to one parent. It's only just begun. They're going for sole custody and I'm powerless to stop it.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> My daughters repeatedly ask for mom. I've seen my oldest daughter's school portal where she writes letters to me that she isn't allowed to send. Her doctor has reached out to me asking why her father hasn't brought her to her regular checkups for her medical condition. He lies and says she resides with him when eyewitnesses have stated they have seen all other members of his family except do my daughter. My youngest (with the other man who is now my ex's bff) is confined to a playroom, is in full time year round daycare while her father sits unemployed in a million dollar home asking me for child support (i work part time and rely on family help). I watch as he tells her that she is happy after she expresses she had a bad day or is sad. She has said she doesn't have friends.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

101 full approved Illinois comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Illinois report comes from Illinois respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Illinois — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 180 Illinois families reporting here are not the universe of Illinois families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – October 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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